

Appendix S: PTSD Checklist for DSM-5 (PCL-5)

Instructions: Below is a list of problems that people sometimes have in response to a very stressful experience. Please read each problem and then select one of the options to indicate how much you have been bothered by that problem **in the past month**. The options include not at all, a little bit, moderately, quite a bit, and extremely.

In the past month, how much were you bothered by:	Not at all	A little bit	Moderately	Quite a bit	Extremely
1. Repeated, disturbing, and unwanted memories of the stressful experience?	0	1	2	3	4
2. Repeated, disturbing dreams of the stressful experience?	0	1	2	3	4
3. Suddenly feeling or acting as if the stressful experience were actually happening again (as if you were actually back there reliving it)?	0	1	2	3	4
4. Feeling very upset when something reminded you of the stressful experience?	0	1	2	3	4
5. Having strong physical reactions when something reminded you of the stressful experience (for example, heart pounding, trouble breathing, sweating)?	0	1	2	3	4
6. Avoiding memories, thoughts, or feelings related to the stressful experience?	0	1	2	3	4
7. Avoiding external reminders of the stressful experience (for example, people, places, conversations, activities, objects, or situations)?	0	1	2	3	4
8. Trouble remembering important parts of the stressful experience?	0	1	2	3	4

In the past month, how much were you bothered by:	Not at all	A little bit	Moderately	Quite a bit	Extremely
9. Having strong negative beliefs about yourself, other people, or the world (for example, having thoughts such as: I am bad, there is something seriously wrong with me, no one can be trusted, the world is completely dangerous)?	0	1	2	3	4
10. Blaming yourself or someone else for the stressful experience or what happened after it?	0	1	2	3	4
11. Having strong negative feelings such as fear, horror, anger, guilt, or shame?	0	1	2	3	4
12. Loss of interest in activities that you used to enjoy?	0	1	2	3	4
13. Feeling distant or cut off from other people?	0	1	2	3	4
14. Trouble experiencing positive feelings (for example, being unable to feel happiness or have loving feelings for people close to you)?	0	1	2	3	4
15. Irritable behavior, angry outbursts, or acting aggressively?	0	1	2	3	4
16. Taking too many risks or doing things that could cause you harm?	0	1	2	3	4
17. Being 'super alert' or watchful or on guard?	0	1	2	3	4
18. Feeling jumpy or easily startled?	0	1	2	3	4
19. Having difficulty concentrating?	0	1	2	3	4
20. Trouble falling or staying asleep?	0	1	2	3	4

Source: Weathers, F. W., Litz, B. T., Keane, T. M., Palmieri, P. A., Marx, B. P., & Schnurr, P. P. (2013). *The PTSD Checklist for DSM-5 (PCL-5) - Standard* [Measurement instrument]. Available from www.ptsd.va.gov.

PCL-5: Scoring and interpretation

Respondents are asked to rate how bothered they have been by each of 20 items in the past month on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 0-4 (0 = Not at all, 1 = A little bit, 2 = Moderately, 3 = Quite a bit, 4 = Extremely). Items are summed to provide a total severity score (range 0-80).

The PCL-5 can determine a **provisional** diagnosis in two ways:

- Summing all 20 items (range 0-80) and using a cut-point score of 31-33 which appears to be reasonable based upon current psychometric work. However, when choosing a cut-off score, it is essential to consider the goals of the assessment and the population being assessed. The lower the cut-off score, the more lenient the criteria for inclusion, increasing the possible number of false-positives. The higher the cut-off score, the more stringent the inclusion criteria and the more potential for false-negatives.
- Treating each item rated as 2 = 'Moderately' or higher as a symptom endorsed, then following the DSM-5 diagnostic rules which requires at least: 1 Criterion B item (questions 1-5), 1 Criterion C item (questions 6-7), 2 Criterion D items (questions 8-14), 2 Criterion E items (questions 15-20). In general, use of a cut-off score tends to produce more reliable results than the DSM-5 diagnostic rule.

If a patient meets a provisional diagnosis using either of the methods above, they need further assessment (e.g., Clinical Administered PTSD Scale for DSM-5: CAPS-5) to confirm a diagnosis of PTSD.

There are currently no empirically derived severity ranges for the PCL-5.

